relationship with the company's Agents in Colombo and Bombay. That they kept in touch with an imprisoned—and helpless—VOC even when their relationship with SSNCo soured speaks for his character and stature.

If this was the big picture, there were daily troubles at the seafront. Though the Swadeshi challenge was limited to one port town, BI felt threatened and feared that its monopoly would be dented. The British company took the challenge seriously. European businessmen ganged up with the police and the administration to crush the fledgling company. With no laws to control monopolistic practices, BI indulged in untrammelled rate cuts. SSNCo vs BI rivalry was a hopeless contest to say the least. BI not only dipped deep into its pockets, it had no compunctions in using the state apparatus against its rival. With the bitter competition spilling into the streets, SSNCo's employees and supporters bore the brunt of police high-handedness and judicial bias.

For V.O. Chidambaram Pillai SSNCo was a political project. As a key figure in the Tilak camp of the Indian National Congress, he drew national attention to the company through his political engagement. As he travelled the length and breadth of the presidency, crowds gathered wherever he spoke. VOC mobilized people by employing the Tamil language for political communication—a novelty until then. Both share capital for the shipping company and political capital for the freedom struggle were accumulated thus. In this process, VOC eclipsed a pantheon of earlier moderate leaders and emerged as the new face of nationalism in south India, and its first mass leader.

As the Swadeshi movement gathered force propelled by SSNCo, the government of Madras brought to bear its heavy hand to crush the company. In the aftermath of the Tirunelveli 'Riots', hundreds were jailed and a large punitive police force was stationed in Tirunelveli and Tuticorin. Handing out a draconian sentence to VOC was the ultimate weapon. The attitude of the state—from its lowly minions to His Excellency the governor—was flagrantly mean and hostile. Governor Lawley barely concealed his hostility when the Tirunelveli deputation met him. The colonial state ensured that VOC was not spared any of the punishments sanctioned by the jail manual.